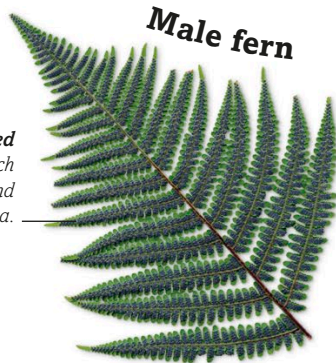


Fern fronds



Soft tree fern

This feather-shaped fern is native to much of Europe, Asia, and North America.



Male fern

Furled fronds are known as fiddleheads because they look like the scrolls of violins.



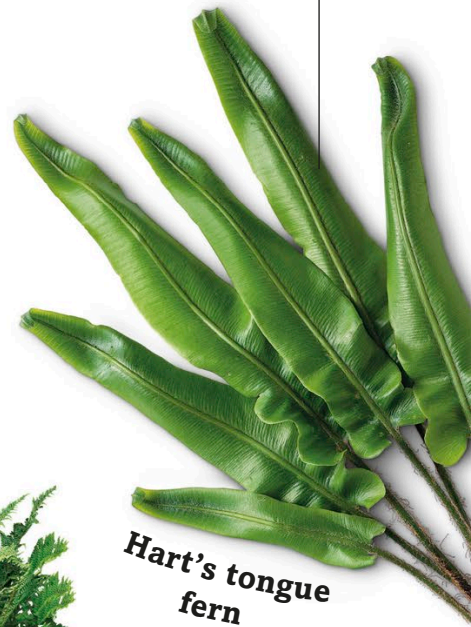
Soft shield fern

Brown, spore-producing specks on the underside are called sori.



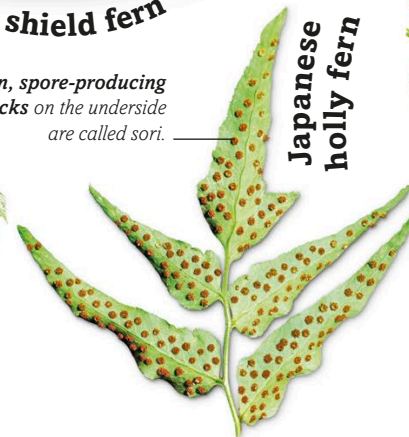
Tree-like habit

These simple fronds are said to look like deer tongues.



Hart's tongue fern

Clumps of fronds grow from a short stem at the base.



Japanese holly fern



Ferns are among the most primitive land plants. As most live on shady forest floors, they make large leaves, called fronds, to help them gather as much sunlight as possible. Many ferns share a distinctive leaf shape, with leaflets that divide, and then divide again. Ferns do not produce flowers. Instead, they grow tiny spores on the underside of their leaves, which are blown by the wind and eventually grow into new plants.